

Data Validation (Drop-down List)

What is Data Validation?

Data Validation is used to control what data users can enter in a cell.

The most common use is creating a **Drop-down List**.

Benefits

- ✓ Prevents typing mistakes
 - ✓ Standardizes data entry
 - ✓ Improves MIS report accuracy
 - ✓ Makes forms user-friendly
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Example

Instead of typing:

Present
Absent
Leave

every time, create a drop-down list.

User simply selects an option.

Demo Table

Employee Name	Status
Ravi	▼
Priya	▼

Kumar ▼

Anitha ▼

Drop-down options:

Present

Absent

Leave

=====

Step-by-Step Procedure

Step 1

Type the options somewhere in the sheet:

D

Presen

t

Absent

Leave

Step 2

Select cells:

B2:B5

Step 3

Go to:

Data Tab → Data Validation

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The screenshot shows a Google Sheets interface. The active range is A2:A4, containing the values 'Present', 'Absent', and 'Leave'. A dropdown menu is open, displaying various data management options. The options are: Sort sheet, Sort range, Create a filter, Create group by view, Create filter view, Add a slicer, Protect sheets and ranges (highlighted), Named ranges, Named functions, Randomize range, Column stats, Data validation, Data cleanup, and Split text to columns.

	A	B
1	D	
2	Present	
3	Absent	
4	Leave	
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		
11		
12		
13		
14		
15		
16		
17		
18		

The screenshot shows a Google Sheets interface with a data validation rule applied to the range A2:A4, C2:C4. The rule is 'Value contains one from list'. The list of values is 'Present', 'Absent', and 'Leave'. The dropdown menu is open, showing the selected value 'Present'.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
1	D		D					
2	Present		Present					
3	Absent		Absent					
4	Leave		Leave					
5								
6								
7								
8								
9								
10								
11								
12								
13								
14								
15								
16								
17								
18								

Data validation rules

Value contains one from list

A2:A4,C2:C4

Remove all + Add rule

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Step 4

Under Settings:

Allow = List

Step 5

Source:

=D\$2:D\$4

Click **OK**.

Result

Each cell in B2:B5 will show:



When clicked:

Present

Absent

Leave

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Sales MIS Example

Employee	Performance
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Ravi	▼
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Priya	▼
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Kumar ▼

Options:

Excellent

Good

Average

Poor

Source:

=\$D\$2:\$D\$5

What are two ways to create a dropdown list?

A:

1. Enter values directly in Data Validation (Present, Absent, Leave).
2. Use a cell range (D1:D3) as the source.

For learning MIS and reporting, I recommend using **"Dropdown from a range"** because it is easier to update later. For example, if HR adds a new status like **WFH**, you only need to add it to the source list.

The screenshot shows an Excel spreadsheet with the following data:

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I
1	Employee	D							
2	Ravi	Leave							
3	Priya	Absent							
4	Kumar	Leave							
5									
6									
7									
8									
9									
10									

The Data Validation Rules pane on the right shows the following rule:

- Value contains one from list
- B2:B4
- Buttons: Remove all, + Add rule